

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Emergency water storage

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QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Store at least one gallon of water per person per day for three days; aim for two weeks if practical. Allow more for heat, illness, pregnancy and pets. Use commercially bottled water or clean food-grade containers, and keep it cool and away from chemicals.

Do now.

**Calculate needs**

01

Count people and days and add water for pets and extra needs.

**Choose containers**

02

Use commercially bottled water or food-grade containers intended for water.

**Label and store**

03

Mark fill dates and store away from sunlight, fuel and cleaning products.

**Rotate supplies**

04

Follow bottled-water dates and replace self-filled stored water every six months.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Calculate the household quantity on paper and store smaller containers if lifting a large container is difficult. Keep one portable supply ready. Divide storage between safe places so damage to one container does not lose all the household water.

Watch for.

Do not reuse containers that held toxic substances, even after washing.

People & practical needs.

Build the plan around the least mobile person and the shortest critical supply. Try carrying the kit, opening containers and using the light in the dark. Spend first on safe water, essential medicines, basic food and communication rather than specialised gear you cannot use. For this situation, brief every person on the first action: calculate needs. Agree who will manage children, pets or mobility needs while that action happens. Do not reuse containers that held toxic substances, even after washing.

Keep essentials within reach.

For emergency water storage, prioritize only items needed for the first action and the fallback: Calculate the household quantity on paper and store smaller containers if lifting a large container is difficult. Keep one portable supply ready. Divide storage between safe places so damage to one container does not lose all the household water. Keep the relevant checklist and contact information within reach. Equipment retrieval must not delay the protective step.

Next decisions.

Learn the local advisory system. Plan how to transport water if distribution sites open.

First decision: Calculate needs

Count people and days and add water for pets and extra needs. Decide which person can carry this out immediately and what would prevent it in your current location. Do not delay the protective step to complete a household worksheet.

When the original plan fails

Calculate the household quantity on paper and store smaller containers if lifting a large container is difficult. Keep one portable supply ready. Divide storage between safe places so damage to one container does not lose all the household water. Reassess the next available location or resource using the warning signs in this guide; do not assume a promised service is operating.

Before changing location

Do not reuse containers that held toxic substances, even after washing. Check the actual route and the needs of the person who will have the most difficulty moving. A destination is not confirmed until access and conditions have been checked.

Questions in the field.

What matters before collecting supplies?

Store at least one gallon of water per person per day for three days; aim for two weeks if practical. Allow more for heat, illness, pregnancy and pets. Use commercially bottled water or clean food-grade containers, and keep it cool and away from chemicals. Collect items only if doing so does not delay this action.

What should another household member do?

Use a second person to handle communication or dependents while the first carries out the immediate action. For emergency water storage, keep the specific hazard in view: Do not reuse containers that held toxic substances, even after washing.

What should be written down?

Record when the situation changed, what action was taken and what remains uncertain. For this situation, start with: Rotate supplies. Follow bottled-water dates and replace self-filled stored water every six months. Keep personal notes private; they are not submitted to Osprey Zero.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

Emergency water storage · official guidance

<https://www.cdc.gov/water-emergency/about/how-to-create-and-store-an-emergency-water-supply.html>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/preparedness/water-storage/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.